

From Self-Doubt to Self-Reliance: Lalita Devi's Entrepreneurial Journey

"पहले तो हमारे को अपनी पहचान नहीं थी कि हम कौन हैं... अब जहाँ मर्जी बोलो, चली जाती हूँ।"

There was a time when Lalita Devi didn't go out of her house without thinking. Talking to people made her feel uneasy and like women in the village she had to ask others for even small amounts of money. Now the same woman speaks with customers takes part in events shows her products and helps other women start their businesses. Her story is not about making herbal soaps—it is about finding confidence finding who she is and becoming financially independent, by working together with others.



Lalita Devi, member of Shiv Self Help Group, has transformed her confidence and livelihood through entrepreneurship.

Beginning of the Journey

Lalita Devi lives in Pohara village in Raith Block of Kangra district. She has been part of the Shiv Self Help Group under the National Rural Livelihood Mission (NRLM) since 2013. She joined the Self Help Group years ago. The group started making soaps, detergent powder and phenyl only about a year ago. Six women came together with the goal. They wanted to create a way to earn money while staying in their village. Before they started the business none of the women had any experience in making cleaning products. They learned how to make the products by doing training. They started making herbal soaps. They use ingredients like goat milk, rice extract, coconut oil, glycerine rose water and Vitamin E capsules. Every product is made by hand. They do not use machines. This shows their commitment, to quality and natural ingredients.

A Business Built on Trust

The group did not put their products on the market away. They made soaps, Used them in their own homes. This way they could see how good the soaps were and feel sure about them before they sold them to people.

Their families and the people who lived near them liked the soaps and wanted more. The women saw that they had made something that people really wanted. People told their friends about the soaps and more people in the village were buying them.

More and more people wanted to buy the soaps so the group got the registration they needed like the Udyam Registration. This helped them sell the soaps in places around town.

Now the group sells soaps to people who just want a few and to people who want to buy a lot. Some people even buy many, as 500 soap bars at one time.



Handmade herbal soaps by the women-led enterprise.

More Than an Income

For Lalita Devi, the biggest achievement is not the number of products sold. It is the confidence she has gained.

She remembers that before joining the Self Help Group she rarely spoke in public and relied on others whenever money was needed. Even asking for an amount of financial support was uncomfortable. Being part of the Self Help Group changed this completely.

Regular meetings, working together and managing the enterprise helped her learn about planning get loans when needed and talk confidently with customers.

Today she is proud to say that she can travel, go to exhibitions talk to buyers and sell her products without any hesitation.

In her own words,

"पहले मुझे लोगों से बात करने में डर लगता था। आज मैं पूरे आत्मविश्वास के साथ कहीं भी जाकर अपने उत्पाद बेच सकती हूँ। अब मुझे कोई झिझक महसूस नहीं होती क्योंकि मुझे पता है कि मैं सक्षम हूँ।"

This transformation reflects the true impact of women's entrepreneurship—not only increasing income but also building self-belief.

The Impact of IIT Delhi Training and Market Exposure

The women took part in programs that helped them become better at running their businesses. These programs taught them a lot of things. They learned how to show their products in a way, how to package them, how to talk to customers and how to sell them in the market.

All of these skills gave the women confidence to make their products better and sell them at exhibitions and show them to people who had never seen them before. The things they learned helped the women think about more, than making products. They started to build a business that would last in the area where they live. The entrepreneurship development programs and capacity-building programs really helped the women on their journey.



Looking Ahead

Lalita Devi dreams of seeing her products reach many more households across Himachal Pradesh and beyond. She hopes to expand production, reach larger markets, and encourage more women to join the enterprise.

Her message to other women is simple yet powerful:

"Do not hesitate to start. Every small step gives you confidence, and confidence changes your life."